

Strategic disruptions: the subnational targeting of internet shutdowns in India

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Abstract

Since 2016, governments in 77 countries have implemented 1,118 internet shutdowns, revealing a growing trend in the use of ‘digital repression.’ Governments often justify these shutdowns as necessary for public safety and applied impartially in response to security threats. Focusing on India, the country that has enacted the most shutdowns globally, this paper explores whether shutdowns instead follow a logic of targeting political opponents, and how they compare with traditional forms of physical repression. The results align with a theory of strategic political targeting as shutdowns are predominantly executed in areas with lower ruling party support, following opposition violence, and prior to escalations in military violence. This pattern differs significantly from that of physical repression, revealing that internet shutdowns are a unique and politically motivated tool used by those in power to suppress opposition and facilitate state-sanctioned violence.

1 Introduction

Free and unfettered internet access has become an essential component of democratic processes. Modern citizens rely on the internet for access to information, economic activities, and personal communication. Moreover, the internet has become a vital tool for upholding and expanding political freedoms. Activists often leverage online platforms to voice their grievances, expose human rights abuses, and mobilize dissent (Enikolopov, Makarin and Petrova, 2020; Manacorda and Tesei, 2020; Pierskalla and Hollenbach, 2013). As a result, information and communication technology (ICT) presents a challenge to ruling authorities, enabling the spread of potentially destabilizing information and facilitating the coordination of opposition efforts. Therefore, governments might be motivated to strategically limit ICT access to fortify their rule.

State repression is not a new phenomenon. Autocratic regimes are often characterized by the use of repressive measures to raise the costs of dissent and maintain authority (Danne-man and Ritter, 2014; Davenport, 2007; Nordås and Davenport, 2013). Traditional physical repression includes direct actions against adversaries, such as targeted killings, imprisonment of key figures, and forceful suppression of protests. While often effective in the short term, these methods can provoke further resistance against the regime (Francisco, 1995; Moore, 2000), empower opposition groups (Kalyvas, 2006), and hinder the government’s ability to collect information about its citizens (Wintrobe, 2000). Furthermore, implementing physical repression requires training, arming, and deploying violent actors who might ultimately become threats to the regime itself (Svolik, 2013). Therefore, despite its frequent use, physical repression can be costly, inefficient, and slow to enact.

Digital repression, which involves the use of modern technologies for political control (Frantz, Kendall-Taylor and Wright, 2020), offers an efficient alternative to physical repression. These digital tactics are often more subtle, involving fewer unpredictable actors and lower risks of public backlash (King, Pan and Roberts, 2013; Qin, Strömberg and Wu, 2017; Roberts, 2018; Shadmehr and Bernhardt, 2015). The use of digital repression, however, does not exclude the simultaneous deployment of physical measures. In fact, governments often combine these tactics to enhance the effectiveness of their repressive efforts while curbing the

risk of backlash. By controlling online communication, authorities can effectively limit the dissemination of information regarding acts of violence or human rights abuses, thus obscuring evidence that could lead to public outcry or international condemnation. For instance, during the Syrian civil war, network disruptions were linked to episodes of intensified state violence, suggesting a deliberate attempt to hinder the flow of information (Gohdes, 2015). A similar strategy was observed in Ethiopia, where the government enforced an internet blackout in anticipation of a military offensive in the Tigray region in November 2020 (Gohdes, 2020). These actions underscore the dual utility of ICT as both a means of suppression and a complement to physical force, offering a cost-effective and versatile tool for governments to maintain control and suppress dissent.

Internet shutdowns, defined as the deliberate disruption of network connectivity in specific areas or for particular groups (Esq and Dada, 2017; Rydzak, 2018), hinder political accountability by suppressing online communication and obstructing mobilization. These shutdowns restrict the dissemination of information, reducing awareness of grievances and protest activities, as well as instances of state repression. While there is a debate over their efficacy in suppressing protests, with some studies suggesting they might actually embolden radical factions and trigger violence (Hassanpour, 2014; Rydzak, 2019), internet shutdowns are increasingly employed as a tool of control by both democratic and autocratic governments. Often justified under the guise of combating fake news, ensuring public safety, or protecting national security, there is growing evidence that governments use these shutdowns to oppress their populations, particularly during critical times like elections (Sutterlin, 2020), protests (Wagner, 2018), and periods of increased state violence (Gohdes, 2015).

In this study, I investigate the practice of internet shutdowns in India, a key case for understanding this phenomenon. India has recently become the world’s most populous nation and ranks second in the number of internet users. However, India also stands out as the leading perpetrator of internet shutdowns. Unlike many countries that impose nationwide shutdowns,¹ the authority to shut down the internet in India rests with state officials, resulting in more geographically targeted shutdowns aimed at specific districts or cities. Leveraging

¹Prominent examples of nation-wide shutdowns include Egypt during the Arab Spring in 2011, Myanmar during the 2020 coup, and Iran during the 2022 protests.

India’s localized approach to issuing shutdowns, I employ a time-series cross-sectional design with time and unit fixed effects to examine the local factors driving these shutdown decisions. The goal of this analysis is to uncover the underlying motives behind internet shutdowns in India and compare them with physical repression tactics, thereby shedding light on the distinct dynamics and strategic advantages of each approach.

The results reveal that internet shutdowns in India are deployed in a politically calculated manner. Districts that are supportive of the state ruling party are less likely to experience internet shutdowns than opposition dominated areas, even when accounting for concurrent levels of violence. The actors involved in these violent events are also crucial, with shutdowns occurring more frequently following violence perpetrated by opposition parties. Furthermore, government officials appear to use internet shutdowns preemptively, often implementing them prior to launching domestic military offensives, particularly in areas with ongoing insurgencies. These patterns differ significantly from the use of physical repression, which is not precisely targeted towards opposition strongholds, in response to opposition-led violence, or prior to military offensives. These findings suggest that internet shutdowns provide governments with a more manageable and targeted means of repression than traditional physical tactics. This strategic and politically motivated use of internet shutdowns challenges optimistic views that ICT acts as a tool for empowering the oppressed. Instead, it indicates that digital technologies, when wielded by repressive regimes, can further tilt the balance of power in their favor.

This paper makes three key contributions to the literature on ICT and repression. First, it shifts focus from the consequences of internet shutdowns, which include adverse economic (Kathuria et al., 2018; West, 2016), social (Mawii et al., 2018; S.K. and Lakshané, 2018), and political effects (Hassanpour, 2014; Rydzak, Karanja and Opiyo, 2020; Stoycheff, Burgess and Martucci, 2020), to the determinants behind these shutdowns. Building on two recent studies (Collyer and Wright, 2021; Ruijgrok, 2022), this paper uses a district-level analysis to better understand how local heterogeneity in political support and contention influence the implementation of internet shutdowns. Second, the paper improves our understanding of how ICT alters the dynamic relationship between protest and repression. While ICT has been celebrated for empowering protest movements (Howard and Hussain, 2011; Little, 2016;

Shirky, 2008; Steinert-Threlkeld, 2017), governments are increasingly using it to suppress dissent (Gunitsky, 2015; King, Pan and Roberts, 2017; Roberts, 2018). This suggests that ICT is a double-edged sword, serving as a technology of liberation while also being actively manipulated and curtailed by repressive governments, even in democratic settings.

Lastly, this research offers a new perspective on the evolving strategies of state coercion. Governments have a diverse array of repressive tools at their disposal (Bagozzi, Berliner and Welch, 2021), and when selecting among these tools, officials must weigh potential benefits against the associated costs. While physical repression involves considerable logistical challenges, the control maintained by Indian authorities over national internet infrastructure allows them to swiftly and selectively shut down the internet. The paper’s findings underscore how the strategic use of internet shutdowns align with political motivations, highlighting the move towards more technologically advanced and strategically sophisticated forms of state control.

2 Internet shutdowns and politics in India

India, recognized as the world’s largest democracy, operates under a federal parliamentary system that grants significant power to state governments. The country’s political scene is primarily dominated by two major parties: the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Indian National Congress (INC). Since the BJP came to power in 2014 under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, it has remained the national ruling party and, as of 2024, governs 18 of the 28 states and administers most union territories.² During the BJP’s tenure, India has shown signs of democratic erosion, including increased polarization, threats to minority rights, and limitations on the freedom of expression and assembly (Varshney, 2022). India has also witnessed a rise in communal violence, particularly between Hindus and Muslims, as well as several large-scale protests like the Farmer Protests and Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) Protests. The Indian government’s handling of these situations has

²Union territories in India are usually administered by the national government - as is the case for six out of eight of these territories. However, Delhi and Puducherry are exceptions, having their own state legislative assemblies and chief ministers. The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) governs Delhi, while Puducherry is under BJP rule.

drawn criticism, particularly regarding allegations of police brutality and internet shutdowns. These developments are reflected in Freedom House’s 2021 reclassification of India as ‘partly free’ and its designation as an ‘electoral autocracy’ by the Regimes of the World index published by the Varieties of Democracy project.

Internet shutdowns, despite international criticism and calls for restraint from human rights organizations, have emerged as a prevalent strategy for governmental control. Such disruptions are not only common but have been recognized by the United Nations as breaches of international human rights laws when they deliberately obstruct the flow of online information. Paradoxically, India, with its rapid expansion of internet access - boasting the second highest number of internet users in the world - stands out as the leading perpetrator of internet shutdowns.

As depicted in Figure 1, the frequency of internet shutdowns in India has increased sharply in the last decade, peaking in 2018 and maintaining high levels thereafter.³ The occurrence of these shutdowns has been widespread across India, affecting 26 of its 36 states and union territories, as shown in Figure 2. Unlike many countries that impose nationwide blackouts, shutdowns in India typically occur at the state or district level. This is a result of India’s configuration of jurisdictional authority over network disruptions which grants power to both central and state governments under certain circumstances.

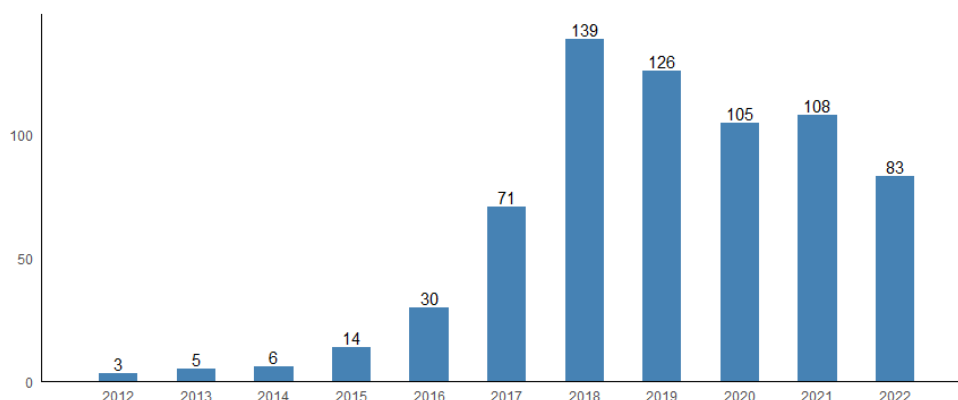


Figure 1. Number of recorded internet shutdowns in India

Jammu and Kashmir has been particularly impacted, experiencing 423 internet shut-

³Internet shutdown data from 2016 to 2022 is sourced from Access Now, while data for prior years comes from the Software Freedom Law Center (SFLC) India.

downs since 2016, the highest in the country. Officially, these shutdowns are often rationalized as necessary to counteract separatist insurgencies and violence. However, concerns are growing that they serve to conceal human rights violations perpetrated by state forces. Specifically, in Jammu and Kashmir, there have been alarming reports of human rights abuses, such as night raids, enforced disappearances, and the use of excessive force against protesters, coinciding with the internet blackouts (UN, 2019). Human rights advocates have strongly criticized these practices, urging the Indian government to end excessive restrictions on internet access in the region. Adding to the complexity, in 2019, the Indian Parliament redefined Jammu and Kashmir as a union territory directly administered by the central government. This shift granted the central government enhanced control over network disruptions in the territory, a power it has exercised numerous times since the reconstitution. This development has intensified concerns over the centralization of authority and the potential for abuses under the guise of maintaining public order in the region.

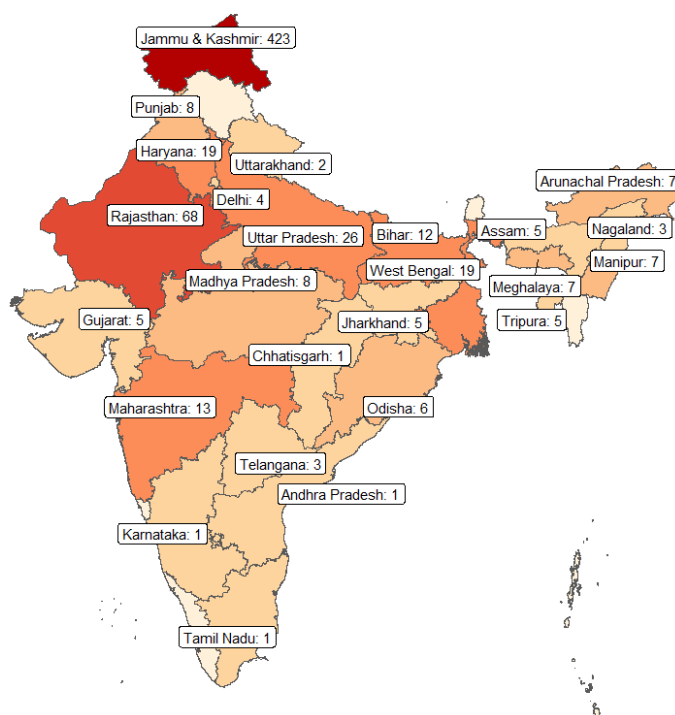


Figure 2. Recorded internet shutdowns in India by state, 2016-2022

The most common official justification for executing an internet shutdown in India is to

maintain public safety or national security during violent unrest and state security operations. Officials have also asserted that shutdowns were used to thwart the spread of fake news, hate speech, and illegal content and to prevent cheating on exams.⁴ Despite official claims, there is reason to suspect that the true intentions behind many of these shutdown orders are not purely to uphold public safety, but instead are the result of strategic calculations made by officials to stifle the freedoms of political opposition groups. Shutdowns in India have increasingly been documented amid protest movements, such as the Indian Farmers' Protest and the protests against the Citizen Amendment Act. Furthermore, recent elections in India have also been marred by internet shutdowns. For instance, during the 2019 general election, network disruptions were reported in Rajasthan, West Bengal, and Kashmir, blocking voters from accessing important information as they prepared to cast their ballots.

2.1 How do internet shutdowns occur?

Governments execute internet shutdowns by exerting influence over the domestic internet infrastructure through state-owned internet service providers (ISPs) or by pressuring privately-owned ISPs, threatening to revoke their operating licenses unless they comply with government demands. In India, internet shutdowns are primarily initiated through court orders issued to ISPs by State and Union Home Secretaries (Singh, Grover and Bansal, 2020). Originally, shutdowns were administered under Section 144 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, granting District Magistrates, the highest ranking officials at the district-level, broad discretionary powers during periods of heightened violence. However, the 2017 Temporary Suspension of Telecom Services (Public Emergency or Public Safety) Rules shifted this authority, enabling senior officials at both the national and state levels to issue shutdown orders during emergencies or to maintain public safety (Singh, Grover and Bansal, 2020). These orders are carried out by civil servants in the Indian Administrative Service (IAS). While originally conceived as a non-political entity, the IAS is significantly influenced by political forces, particularly through the manipulation of civil service appointments and transfers (Ruijgrok, 2022). As a result, these civil servants are incentivized to respond to the political

⁴See Figure A.C.1 for the distribution of justifications given for internet shutdown orders in India.

priorities established by their respective state governments, including implementing targeted shutdowns.

The regulation of shutdowns in India has faced legal challenges. In 2019, the Gauhati High Court contested a shutdown in Assam, demanding the restoration of internet services. In 2020, the Supreme Court upheld the constitutional protection of internet freedom (Rautray, 2020), mandating public disclosure of shutdown orders and reviewing the suspension in Jammu and Kashmir (Jain, 2020). Furthermore, the Parliament Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology criticized routine shutdowns for non-emergency situations in 2021, recommending a review of relevant laws and monitoring of shutdown orders (Singh, 2022). Despite legal advancements, the persistent and impactful nature of shutdowns in India underscores the importance of understanding how they are used and their effects on politics in India.

2.2 Political violence in India

In India’s dynamic political landscape, violence often accompanies electoral competition. This partisan violence—distinct from communal or insurgent violence—emerges as political parties engage in clashes, intimidation, and coercion to gain electoral advantage. Partisan violence is not purely a result of ethnic or religious tensions, nor does it mirror the objectives of insurgent groups, which aim to disrupt or delegitimize the political system itself through separatist agendas or election boycotts. Instead, partisan violence is instrumental and strategic, carried out by political actors to influence electoral outcomes directly, primarily by suppressing opposition activity and voter turnout.

While communal violence can overlap with electoral motives, where political actors manipulate ethnic or religious tensions for political gain (Brass, 1997, 2011), the key distinction lies in intent. Partisan violence aims to weaken opponents during elections, whereas communal violence often reflects deeper societal divisions that outlast electoral cycles. However, these forms of violence can blur, as political actors may suppress or exploit ethnic identity and communal unrest to serve partisan goals (Bulutgil and Prasad, 2023; Wilkinson, 2004). For instance, the INC strategically suppressed ethnic violence during its incumbency to protect its multiethnic coalition and prevent polarization that could benefit Hindu nationalist

rivals like the BJP (Nellis et al., 2016). Ultimately, while communal violence fosters long-term divides, partisan violence is tactical and focused on electoral outcomes. Recognizing this distinction helps us understand how political actors use violence not only as a governance issue but also as a strategic tool.

Similarly, insurgent violence and partisan violence in India diverge significantly in both objectives and tactics. Insurgent violence, primarily associated with groups like Maoists, Naxalites, and separatist movements in regions such as Kashmir and the Northeast, targets the legitimacy of the state itself (Kohli and Singh, 2013). Insurgent groups often seek systemic change, challenging the political, social, and economic structures that uphold the status quo. Their strategy involves undermining state authority through attacks on government institutions, including election boycotts, polling station attacks, and targeted violence against political officials (Harbers, Richetta and Van Wingerden, 2023). In contrast, partisan violence occurs within the framework of electoral competition. The aim of partisan violence is not to dismantle the state but to operate within the political system, ensuring that the electoral process benefits a particular party or candidate (Wilkinson, 2004).

The study’s emphasis on partisan violence stems from its unique relevance to the phenomenon of internet shutdowns. By focusing on this type of violence, we can more accurately discern the political motivations behind the implementation of these shutdowns. When a government enacts an internet shutdown in response to violence from opposition parties, it is often a strategic decision aimed at suppressing dissent, preventing mobilization, or controlling the political narrative. This is different from shutdowns used to maintain public safety or national security in response to communal or insurgent violence. Moreover, examining partisan violence allows for a clearer understanding of the interplay between government actions and political opposition. In regions where opposition parties are strong, the government may resort to internet shutdowns as a means to curb the influence and reach of these parties, especially during times of heightened political tension or electoral competition. The decision to shut down internet access in such scenarios can be interpreted as an attempt to stifle opposition voices and hamper their ability to organize and protest, rather than as a measure purely for public safety.

3 Theoretical framework

3.1 The logic of internet shutdowns

Repression refers to the “actual or threatened use of physical sanctions for the purpose of imposing a cost on the target as well as deterring specific activities and/or beliefs perceived to be challenging to the government” (Davenport, 2007). Internet shutdowns have emerged as a contemporary form of repression, enabling governments to suppress protest and opposition by disrupting communication and information flows. Moreover, shutdowns can complement physical repression, allowing states to isolate communities and obscure their actions from public scrutiny.

While shutdowns offer a way to stifle dissent and assert authority, they come with significant costs. These include economic losses (Howard, Agarwal and Hussain, 2011), as seen in India’s \$3.04 billion loss resulting from shutdowns between 2012–2017 (Kathuria et al., 2018), and functional limitations, such as restricting the government’s ability to manipulate online discourse (Gunitsky, 2015), divert attention to less threatening topics (King, Pan and Roberts, 2017), or gather intelligence on public grievances and planned protest in order to preempt dissent (Gohdes, 2020). Shutdowns can also backfire, driving citizens to bypass restrictions using tools like virtual private networks (VPNs) and increasing engagement with political issues (Hobbs and Roberts, 2018). Additionally, heavy-handed actions like internet blackouts risk undermining state legitimacy by intensifying public grievances (Huang, 2018).

Governments aim to balance the effectiveness of repression with its costs, adapting tactics based on context. Therefore, we should anticipate diverse approaches to repression, depending on the circumstances, timing, and tools that governments have at their disposal. The next section explores how local political dynamics and the nature of violent incidents influence government officials’ propensity to repress, and their strategic considerations in selecting specific repressive methods.

3.2 Theoretical expectations

Repressive strategies are shaped by local political conditions and the nature of threats to state authority. Governments adapt their methods to maximize effectiveness while minimizing political and reputational risks, carefully calibrating their responses based on the perceived stability or vulnerability of specific regions.

In ruling-party strongholds, officials rarely resort to repression to maintain control, as these regions typically present minimal political threats. However, when repression is deemed necessary, overt tactics such as physical force are more likely to be employed. By leveraging local violent actors, officials can consolidate power, intimidate opponents, and deepen political divisions without significant electoral risks (Bratton and Masunungure, 2007; Fielding, 2018). These actions signal a commitment to maintaining order and protecting constituents with minimal concerns about backlash due to the presence of fewer swing voters. Strongholds thus provide a relatively low-risk environment for overt repression, allowing officials to signal strength and reinforce their authority without significant political costs.

In contested districts, however, overt repression carries higher risks. Research on election violence has found that heavy-handed tactics can alienate undecided voters and galvanize opposition support (Daxecker and Rauschenbach, 2023; Rauschenbach and Paula, 2019), as well as attract national or international scrutiny that can damage government legitimacy (Höglund and Piya Rathne, 2009). These regions demand more subtle forms of control, such as internet shutdowns, which allow governments to suppress dissent without visible violence or direct confrontation.

Internet shutdowns disrupt communication and mobilization efforts, curtailing protests and opposition activities while minimizing backlash and reputational risks. These shutdowns can be selectively and rapidly deployed, targeting specific opposition-dominated areas, disrupting the opposition’s ability to organize, communicate, and mobilize, without alienating key voter groups or risking excessive collateral damage (Condra et al., 2018; Rosenzweig, 2021). This strategy neutralizes immediate threats while undermining the opposition’s longer-term electoral prospects by restricting their ability to campaign and engage with the electorate online. Shutdowns can also be framed as measures maintain public order and

national security, helping state officials justify their actions and reduce backlash from the international community and sympathetic domestic audiences. By leveraging shutdowns, governments in contested districts can maintain control and manage dissent without the overt visibility of physical repression. This approach aligns with research on electoral repression, which emphasizes how governments adapt repressive tactics to local political dynamics (Daxecker and Rauschenbach, 2023; Rauschenbach and Paula, 2019). This leads to my first prediction that districts with lower ruling-party support should be more likely to experience internet shutdowns (Prediction 1).

The identity of violent actors also influences the choice of repressive tactics. Opposition-linked violence not only poses a direct threat to physical security but also challenges the ruling party’s authority. Such threats compel state officials to act decisively to prevent further destabilization. Inaction risks alienating the ruling party’s supporters, who may perceive the government as weak, eroding its legitimacy and base of support. Although physical repression can address these challenges, it is often viewed as a high-cost option due to its visibility, potential for escalation, and risk of international condemnation. Internet shutdowns offer a less visible and more expedient alternative. They are swift to implement and can immediately disrupt the opposition’s ability to communicate, organize, and mobilize, effectively blunting the impact of their actions without the backlash associated with physical force. By restricting access to critical platforms, state officials can control the narrative, prevent opposition mobilization, and mitigate risks of further unrest. Thus, my second prediction posits that internet shutdowns should be more common following violence linked to opposition parties (Prediction 2).

Beyond immediate suppression, internet shutdowns serve broader strategic purposes in managing conflict and unrest. By isolating communities and controlling information flows, shutdowns disrupt organizational efforts and shape narratives, which are critical in modern political conflicts. The absence of online platforms fragments opposition efforts, reducing their capacity to respond to state actions. Shutdowns also limit the rapid dissemination of information about state-led violence, minimizing domestic backlash and international criticism. In military contexts, internet blackouts obscure controversial offensives, enabling authorities to act with reduced scrutiny and intervention risks. This controlled flow of

information allows governments to pursue military objectives with lower reputational costs. These dynamics lead to my third prediction that military-led violence should increase in the wake of internet shutdowns (Prediction 3).

3.3 Alternate expectations

This study examines whether the official justifications for internet shutdowns provided by Indian government authorities align with observed patterns of their implementation. The key question is whether these shutdowns are genuinely aimed at curbing violent unrest and maintaining public safety or if they are politically motivated to disrupt the activities of groups that pose a threat to the ruling party.

If the official narrative holds, we would expect a consistent pattern of internet shutdowns across India, driven primarily by instances of violence rather than political dynamics. Regions experiencing unrest—regardless of their political alignment—should face similar chances of internet disruptions. However, if shutdowns are strategically employed for political gain, the pattern would differ. Shutdowns would be more frequent in regions with stronger opposition support and following violent incidents linked to opposition-affiliated groups, suggesting their use as a tool to undermine political opposition.

Furthermore, if the primary goal of shutdowns is genuinely to manage unrest and public safety, their timing should not systematically align with military operations. While shutdowns implemented before military exercises alone would not constitute definitive evidence of political motivations, in the broader context of findings indicating that shutdowns disproportionately affect opposition areas or occur in response to opposition-led incidents, such timing would provide further insight into their strategic use. There may be legitimate operational reasons to synchronize shutdowns with military activities, such as maintaining operational security or preventing the dissemination of sensitive information. However, when shutdowns are repeatedly bundled with military actions in ways that align with opposition-related events, it suggests a possible strategic dimension—one where shutdowns serve not only as a public safety tool but also as a means to control opposition influence and communications.

4 Research design and data

To analyze how internet shutdowns are targeted in India, I use a time-series cross-sectional design with time and unit fixed effects. This approach leverages subnational variation in the implementation of internet shutdowns, which stems from India’s decentralized internet regulation, enabling state officials to initiate localized network disruptions. The dependent variable is the onset of an internet shutdown in a specific district during a given week. Shutdown events are identified using data from the Shutdown Tracker Optimization Project (STOP) by Access Now, which provides details on the timing, duration, and geographic location of disruptions. For precision in district-level analysis, I matched the specified affected areas in the STOP data to their corresponding districts. In cases where the affected area spanned multiple districts, I included all relevant districts, and I excluded state-wide shutdowns to focus on localized variations. When the end date of a disruption was unspecified, I assumed it lasted for a single day.

The analysis investigates the relationship between internet shutdowns and three key correlates: (1) political support for the ruling state party and (2) violence perpetrated by political opposition groups, and (3) the initiation of military-led operations.

Political support is measured as the vote margin of the ruling party in the most recent state legislative assembly (Vidhan Sabha) election, using data from the Trivedi Centre for Political Data. The ruling party is identified as the party of the Chief Minister, who holds de facto executive authority in the state or union territory, while the primary opposition party is the party that received the highest vote share in each district when excluding the ruling party. The vote margin is calculated as the difference between the ruling party’s vote share and that of the opposition party.

In some districts, the Chief Minister’s party did not field candidates, often due to pre-election coalitions. To avoid misinterpreting this as a lack of support, I identified districts where coalition partners were involved and recalculated the ruling party’s vote share to include these allies. This adjustment ensures the measure reflects the combined support for the coalition.

The ruling party vote margin, shown for each state in Appendix Table A.A.I, ranges

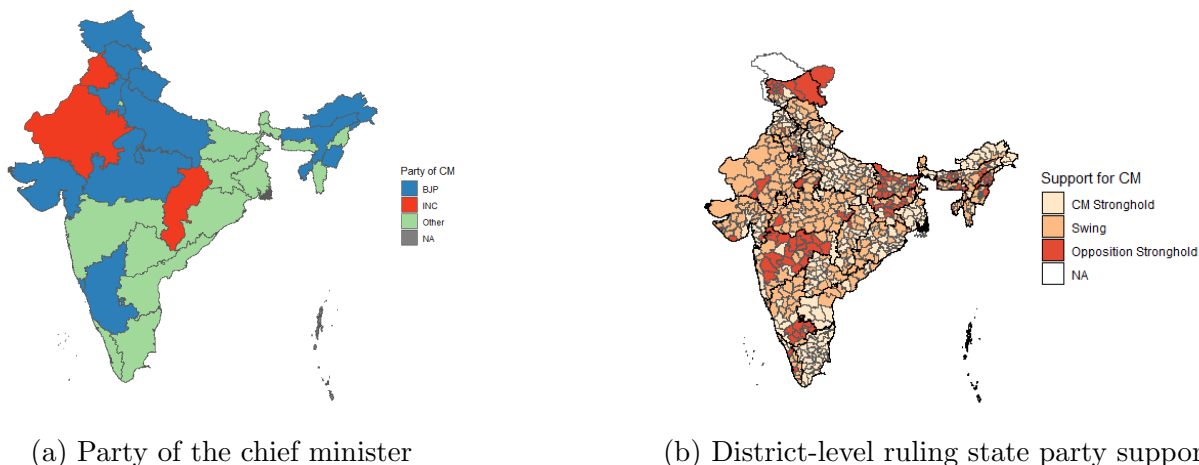


Figure 3. These figures depict the Chief Minister’s party in each state (a) and its district-level of political support (b) in 2021.

from -100 to 100, where -100 indicates the opposition received all the votes and 100 indicates complete support for the Chief Minister’s party. Administrative districts, rather than legislative constituencies, are used as the unit of analysis to align with the geographic units in the internet shutdown data. This aggregation provides a district-level measure of political support, capturing the combined results of multiple assembly constituencies within an administrative district. Figure 3 illustrates the distribution of ruling party support across districts for 2021. According to my first prediction, I expect to find a negative relationship between ruling party support and the likelihood of an internet shutdown.

The second predictor is the number of violent events perpetrated by opposition parties in each district-week. This variable is constructed using data from the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (ACLED), with events classified based on their characteristics and the actors involved.⁵ Perpetrators are identified using coding rules outlined in Appendix B.2, which assign one or both ACLED-listed actors as perpetrators depending on the event type. As detailed in Appendix B.3, opposition-perpetrated violence is defined as events where the perpetrator matches the opposition parties or their affiliates—such as youth wings or women’s branches—active in each state-year. These events are aggregated to calculate the weekly count of opposition-perpetrated violent incidents at the district level. Following

⁵This coding procedure, detailed in Appendix B, was adapted from a working paper by Lauren Young and Marika Miner titled “A Global Analysis of the Targeting and Effects of Election Violence.”

my second prediction, which posits that internet shutdowns are often a response to partisan opposition violence, I expect a positive relationship between such incidents and the likelihood of an internet shutdown.

Third, I investigate the connection between internet shutdowns and instances of military-led violence. In this analysis, the onset of an internet shutdown serves as the independent variable, and military-led violence is the dependent variable. As described in Appendix B.4, military-led violence includes specific violent events perpetrated by Indian government forces and state security services. Consistent with my third prediction that internet shutdowns are used as a cover for domestic military offensives, I anticipate a positive correlation between internet shutdowns and subsequent instances of military-led violence.

Finally, to compare how physical repression is targeted relative to digital strategies like internet shutdowns, I analyze the relationship between state-led physical repression and the primary correlates. Using coding rules in Appendix B.5, I identify physical repression as events with specific characteristics perpetrated by government forces or state security services. This comparison provides insight into how digital and physical repression are employed under varying circumstances.

4.1 Estimation strategy

To test my predictions about the determinants of internet shutdowns in India, I employ a time-series cross-sectional design with time and unit fixed effects. Since official justifications for shutdowns often cite the prevention of violence, it is crucial to account for the possibility that regions prone to violence may naturally experience more shutdowns, independent of political dynamics or the affiliations of those involved in violence. To address this, I include a measure of violent incidents in each district-week and account for violence in neighboring districts, recognizing that shutdowns may be a preemptive response to potential spillover violence. Additionally, I control for non-partisan violence when examining opposition-perpetrated violence to disentangle politically motivated actions from general responses to unrest.

To mitigate potential biases arising from temporal trends, I include week fixed effects⁶,

⁶Week fixed effects refer to each week-year combination in the dataset.

which capture influences such as religious holidays or the enactment of divisive national policies that might affect shutdown decisions.

Indian states vary in administrative practices, internet shutdown regulations, and political dynamics, which may influence shutdown patterns. For instance, parties aligned with the central government might be more inclined to employ shutdowns. To address these variations, I incorporate regional fixed effects: state fixed effects for models examining political support and district fixed effects for those analyzing violence-related shutdowns. This distinction reflects differences in data granularity—political support is measured annually at the state level, while violent events are recorded weekly at the district level. While district fixed effects in models of political support might control for differences among districts within the same state, they are unsuitable here because they would capture the variation I aim to explain. Instead, in addition to state fixed effects, I control for district-level violence, one of the primary confounding factors, and focus on how political support influences the targeting of shutdowns within states. This approach aligns with the observation that state governments impose shutdowns on specific districts within their jurisdiction.

To evaluate the relationship between political support and internet shutdowns, conditional on other relevant characteristics, I estimate the following specification:

$$\text{logit}(\Pr(\text{Shutdown}_{i,t} = 1)) = \alpha + \beta \text{Support}_{i,\text{Election}t-1} + \lambda_1 \text{Violence}_{i,t-1} + \xi \text{ViolentExposure}_{i,t-1} + \gamma_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{i,t} \quad (1)$$

$\text{Shutdown}_{i,t}$ indicates if a shutdown occurred in a district during a specific week, while $\text{Support}_{i,t-1}$ measures political support in that district from the most recent prior state legislative election. $\text{Violence}_{i,t-1}$ and $\text{ViolentExposure}_{i,t-1}$ capture the district’s internal violence level and its exposure to violence from neighboring districts in the previous week, respectively. γ_i represent state fixed effects, capturing individual time-invariant characteristics, and δ_t are week fixed effects, measuring temporal trends common to all units.

For assessing the likelihood of shutdowns following opposition-led violence, I use:

$$\text{logit}(\Pr(\text{Shutdown}_{i,t} = 1)) = \alpha + \beta \text{OppositionViolence}_{i,t-1} + \lambda_1 \text{OtherViolence}_{i,t-1} + \gamma_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{i,t} \quad (2)$$

$\text{OppositionViolence}_{i,t-1}$ denotes violent events perpetrated by opposition groups, and

$OtherViolence_{i,t-1}$ are violent incidents in the district carried out by groups who are unaffiliated with the opposition party. Both are lagged to represent violence in the prior week. γ_i are district fixed effects, while δ_t captures week-specific effects. I also control for district-level exposure to violence from neighboring districts in the previous week.

To explore the relation between internet shutdowns and subsequent military violence, I estimate:

$$MilitaryViolence_{i,t} = \alpha + \beta Shutdown_{i,t-1} + \lambda_1 Violence_{i,t-1} + \gamma_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{i,t} \quad (3)$$

$MilitaryViolence_{i,t}$ measures military-led violent events in a district, with $Shutdown_{i,t-1}$ indicating whether a shutdown occurred in the previous week. $Violence_{i,t-1}$ captures the overall level of violence in a district during the previous week. Again, γ_i and δ_t represent district and week-specific effects and I also control for district-level exposure to violence from neighboring districts in the previous week.

Finally, I apply a similar method to investigate patterns of physical repression, substituting internet shutdowns with instances of state-led physical repression.

5 Results

Consistent with my first prediction, the analysis reveals that districts demonstrating stronger support for the ruling state party are less prone to internet shutdowns. The results, presented in Table I, indicate that a 10% increase in the vote margin for the ruling state party corresponds to a 21% decrease in the odds of experiencing an internet shutdown. Notably, the interaction between political support and violence indicates that while politically supportive districts are less susceptible to internet shutdowns, this negative effect diminishes as the level of violence in the district rises. In other words, when violence is rampant, state officials are more inclined to implement internet shutdowns, even in regions where they enjoy substantial political support.

The patterns for physical repression differ significantly. Districts with higher support for the ruling party are actually more likely to experience physical repression. This finding implies that physical repression, unlike internet shutdowns, is more frequently used in

areas loyal to the ruling party, indicating distinct strategic uses for digital versus physical repression.

Table I. Political support for the state ruling party

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election $t-1$}	-0.0247*** (0.0046)	-0.0232*** (0.0041)	-0.0253*** (0.0044)	0.0080*** (0.0028)	0.0086*** (0.0030)	0.0074** (0.0031)
Violent events _{$t-1$}		0.1122*** (0.0147)	0.1456*** (0.0104)		0.3623*** (0.0876)	0.3590*** (0.0765)
Violent exposure _{$t-1$}		0.0598*** (0.0102)	0.0592*** (0.0097)		0.0481* (0.0257)	0.0490* (0.0256)
Political support _{Election $t-1$} *Violent events _{$t-1$}			0.0018*** (0.0004)			0.0019 (0.0014)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	163,200	163,200	163,200	248,292	248,292	248,292
Pseudo R ²	0.39802	0.41098	0.41151	0.09772	0.12094	0.12125

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table II presents the results examining the likelihood of internet shutdowns following violence led by opposition groups. The results align with my prediction that internet shutdowns are more frequently implemented following acts of partisan violence perpetrated by opposition parties. For each additional event of opposition-linked violence, the odds of a shutdown increase by 30%. This pattern points to targeted shutdowns in areas experiencing opposition-related violence, rather than a general response to all forms of violence as violent incidents carried out by groups unaffiliated with the opposition party do not appear to provoke shutdowns. Conversely, physical repression doesn't show a significant correlation with opposition-instigated violence when controlling for other forms of violence, suggesting that unlike internet shutdowns, physical repression is not specifically responsive to opposition

violence.

Table II. Opposition perpetrated violence

	Internet shutdown		Physical repression	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Opposition violence _{<i>t</i>-1}	0.2739*** (0.0623)	0.2621*** (0.0586)	0.1436*** (0.0347)	-0.0086 (0.0557)
Unaffiliated violence _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0334 (0.0277)		0.1811*** (0.0140)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0127 (0.0122)		0.0682*** (0.0108)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
District	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	45,390	45,390	229,779	229,779
Pseudo R ²	0.39454	0.39514	0.22103	0.22932

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

To further investigate this dynamic, I examined the relationship between opposition violence, internet shutdowns, and physical repression across districts with varying levels of political support. Figure 4 presents the results for ruling party strongholds, swing districts, and opposition strongholds. In swing districts, where electoral competition is most intense, opposition violence is particularly likely to lead to internet shutdowns, underscoring the state’s selective deployment of shutdowns in politically sensitive contexts. Physical repression, in contrast, does not show a similar pattern across these districts, as shown in Appendix Table A.E.IV, indicating that physical repression is not strategically targeted in response to opposition violence based on district-level political alignment.

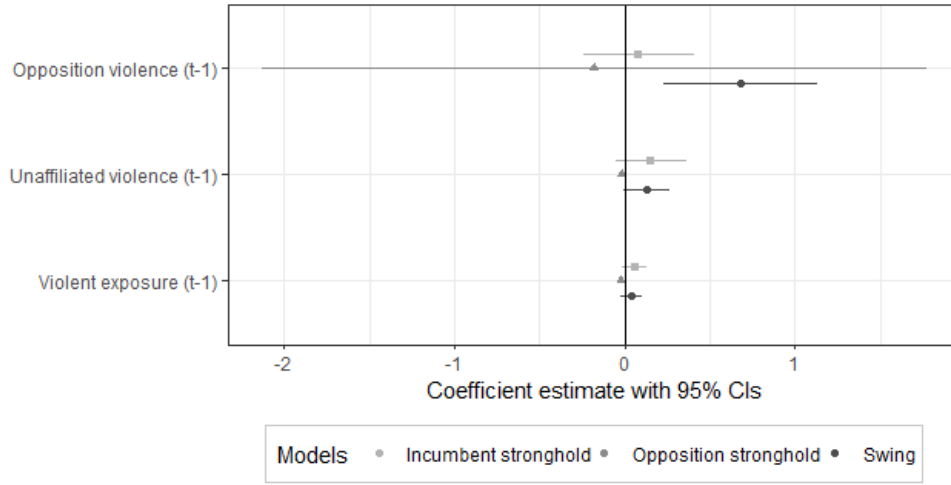


Figure 4. Opposition perpetrated violence by political support category on internet shutdowns

In Appendix D, I explore the combined effects of opposition violence, political support, and ruling-party violence on the likelihood of internet shutdowns and physical repression. Appendix Table A.F.I shows that political support continues to have a negative association with shutdown likelihood, even in districts experiencing significant opposition violence. This suggests that the ruling party’s strongholds are generally shielded from shutdowns, despite opposition activity. While opposition violence does raise the overall probability of shutdowns, its effect loses statistical significance once political support is accounted for, implying that ruling party strength moderates the use of shutdowns. Next, Appendix Table A.F.II presents models examining the impact of opposition-led violence alongside ruling-party violence on shutdowns and physical repression. These results underscore that opposition violence is the primary catalyst for shutdowns, while ruling-party violence shows a negative association with shutdowns and remains statistically insignificant. This pattern indicates that shutdowns are predominantly driven by opposition-linked violence, rather than by violence initiated by the ruling party.

Table III presents the relationship between internet shutdowns and military-led violence. The findings reveal a significant link, showing that the initiation of shutdowns often precedes increased military activities, independent of pre-existing violence levels. In districts where internet shutdowns occur, there is, on average, a 0.05 rise in the frequency of military violent

events in the subsequent week. This increase is in comparison to a baseline prediction of 0.02 military violent events in the absence of a shutdown, escalating to 0.07 in the presence of a shutdown. This contrasts with physical repression, which does not show a significant preemptive link to military-led violence. These distinct patterns highlight the different strategies in digital and physical repression, underscoring the unique targeting approach of internet shutdowns compared to traditional physical repression methods.

Table III. Military-led violence

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Shutdown _{<i>t</i>-1}	0.1233** (0.0489)	0.0468*** (0.0122)		
Physical repression _{<i>t</i>-1}			0.0216 (0.0149)	-0.1240 (0.0816)
Violent events _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0748 (0.0466)		0.0937* (0.0551)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0024*** (0.0005)		0.0025*** (0.0007)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
District	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	251,196	251,196	251,196	251,196
R ²	0.25647	0.27873	0.25606	0.28308

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

5.1 Internet shutdown targeting in conflict zones

The unique political and security dynamics of Jammu and Kashmir, as well as other insurgent-affected areas, play a significant role in the deployment of internet shutdowns. Shutdowns in these regions often serve dual purposes: controlling information flow to address security concerns and advancing political objectives. To capture these nuances, I conducted robustness checks by isolating data from Jammu and Kashmir and distinguishing between insurgent and non-insurgent areas. The findings highlight significant regional and contextual variations in how political support, opposition violence, and military operations influence shutdown patterns.

When Jammu and Kashmir and other insurgent areas are excluded, higher political support correlates with a lower likelihood of shutdowns, though this relationship loses statistical significance. Given that Jammu and Kashmir and insurgent areas account for the highest shutdown frequencies, their inclusion strongly affects overall statistical patterns. However, the persistence of the broader trend even when excluding these high-conflict zones suggests that such regions amplify rather than fundamentally alter the strategy of targeting shutdowns based on political support.

In contrast, focusing exclusively on Jammu and Kashmir and insurgent areas reveals that political support remains a significant predictor, with stronger support for the ruling party linked to a lower likelihood of shutdowns. This finding may seem counterintuitive, as these are high-conflict zones where security priorities might overshadow electoral considerations. Yet, the results suggest that shutdowns in these regions reflect a blend of security imperatives and political calculations. The frequent use of shutdowns in politically sensitive districts within these areas demonstrates the government’s effort to balance these objectives, even in complex conflict environments.

Table IV. Political support for the state ruling party on shutdowns, excluding and only J&K, insurgent and non-insurgent

	Excluding J&K		Only J&K		Non-insurgent		Insurgent	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Political support _{Election $t-1$}	-0.0052 (0.0087)	-0.0053 (0.0088)	-0.0330*** (0.0078)	-0.0306*** (0.0077)	-0.0013 (0.0224)	-0.0012 (0.0232)	-0.0279*** (0.0032)	-0.0255*** (0.0030)
Violent events _{$t-1$}		0.3576*** (0.0475)		0.1216* (0.0721)		0.4481*** (0.1144)		0.1105*** (0.0127)
Violent exposure _{$t-1$}		0.0026 (0.0222)		0.0804*** (0.0267)		-0.0153 (0.0732)		0.0613*** (0.0119)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>								
State	✓	✓			✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	76,260	76,260	4,100	4,100	13,095	13,095	98,728	98,728
Pseudo R ²	0.13851	0.14807	0.20603	0.24483	0.14719	0.15659	0.45502	0.46885

Clustered (state/district & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table V further explores the impact of opposition violence, comparing trends excluding Jammu and Kashmir and other insurgent areas to those focused solely on Jammu and Kashmir and insurgent areas. In line with the national trend, opposition violence is positively associated with shutdown likelihood, even when Jammu and Kashmir is excluded and across insurgent and non-insurgent areas, reflecting a general strategy to control or deter opposition activities. However, this relationship reverses in Jammu and Kashmir, where opposition violence is linked to a reduced likelihood of shutdowns. This divergence suggests that in Jammu and Kashmir, insurgent threats overshadow typical opposition dynamics, reflecting a prioritization of broader security and counterinsurgency strategies over reactions to partisan disturbances. Notably, while Jammu and Kashmir stands out in its response to opposition violence, broader insurgent areas still align with the national trend - using shutdowns in response to opposition activity - indicating that the unique dynamics of Jammu and Kashmir do not entirely extend to other insurgency-affected regions.

Table V. Opposition violence on shutdowns, excluding and only J&K, insurgent and non-insurgent

	Excluding J&K		Only J&K		Non-insurgent		Insurgent	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Opposition violence _{<i>t</i>-1}	0.4054*** (0.0873)	0.2368* (0.1264)	-1.248*** (0.3960)	-1.218*** (0.3711)	0.8376*** (0.2142)	0.8173*** (0.2326)	0.1892** (0.0766)	0.1800** (0.0713)
Unaffiliated violence _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.3669*** (0.0843)		-0.0026 (0.0210)		0.3281 (0.2200)		0.0220 (0.0302)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0023 (0.0288)		-0.0068 (0.0162)		-0.0156 (0.0736)		0.0048 (0.0163)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>								
District	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	19,680	19,680	3,690	3,690	4,107	4,107	24,033	24,033
Pseudo R ²	0.10134	0.10794	0.46904	0.46912	0.12136	0.12504	0.46360	0.46378

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

The relationship between shutdowns and military operations also varies by region, underscoring the strategic use of this tool in different security contexts. The national trend of shutdowns preceding military operations holds only in insurgent regions, where shutdowns frequently occur in advance of military actions, signaling a tactical function within counterinsurgency operations. By curbing information flow in these conflict-prone areas, the government aims to reinforce state control and suppress insurgent movements. Conversely, in non-insurgent areas—and when excluding Jammu and Kashmir—shutdowns correlate negatively with military activity, indicating a more restrained approach in stable regions where military interventions are less common. Within Jammu and Kashmir, shutdowns do initially precede military actions, yet this relationship loses significance when accounting for heightened levels of violence. This suggests that shutdowns in the region respond more flexibly to evolving security threats rather than adhering to a strict pre-military action strategy.

Table VI. Military-led violence and internet shutdowns, excluding and only J&K, insurgent and non-insurgent

	Excluding J&K		Only J&K		Non-insurgent		Insurgent	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Shutdown _{<i>t</i>-1}	-0.0037 (0.0035)	-0.0072* (0.0038)	0.1735* (0.0867)	-0.0329 (0.0900)	-0.0036* (0.0020)	-0.0055** (0.0026)	0.1490*** (0.0365)	0.0533** (0.0208)
Violent events _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0039** (0.0017)		0.1930** (0.0678)		0.0024** (0.0009)		0.0904* (0.0503)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0004** (0.0002)		-0.0036 (0.0057)		0.0002 (0.0002)		0.0021* (0.0011)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>								
District	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	243,936	243,936	7,260	7,260	91,828	91,828	159,368	159,368
R ²	0.06843	0.06878	0.26586	0.32403	0.02127	0.02157	0.25927	0.28614

Clustered (state/district & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

These findings reveal the intricate calculus behind shutdown deployment, highlighting their selective use to address specific regional security challenges. In insurgent areas outside of Jammu and Kashmir, shutdowns are frequently implemented in politically sensitive districts, often in response to opposition violence and coordinated with military operations. Jammu and Kashmir, however, stands out as a distinct case within the broader insurgent landscape. While shutdowns in this region are frequent and strategically targeted, they do not follow the same pattern of responding to opposition violence observed in other high-conflict areas. Moreover, while shutdowns in insurgent regions generally precede military operations, this relationship is less consistent in Jammu and Kashmir when accounting for varying levels of violence. This suggests that shutdowns in the region are more reactive and context-sensitive, reflecting its unique conflict dynamics. In contrast, non-insurgent areas exhibit a more restrained approach, with shutdowns primarily used in response to high lev-

els of opposition violence rather than as a complement to military action. This nuanced strategy highlights how the state adapts its use of internet shutdowns to balance political considerations, suppress opposition, and respond to diverse security pressures across regions.

6 Robustness checks

6.1 Alternative measures of political support

To ensure my findings are not dependent on a single measure of political support, I incorporate two alternative metrics. The first is a binary indicator of whether the Chief Minister’s party secured the majority of votes in a district, offering a straightforward distinction between districts where the ruling party holds a dominant position and those where it does not. The second is a categorical index that classifies districts as ruling party strongholds, swing districts, or opposition strongholds, based on vote share margins.⁷

The results, presented in Appendix E, align with the main findings: shutdowns are less likely in districts where the ruling party is dominant and more likely in opposition strongholds. These patterns reinforce the argument that political support significantly influences the deployment of internet shutdowns. Moreover, these alternative measures confirm that physical repression is more prevalent in districts where the ruling party has strong support.

6.2 Looking beyond violent events

While this paper primarily focuses on violent events, non-violent activities, such as peaceful protests or strikes, may also prompt internet shutdowns. To capture a broader range of triggers, I extend the analysis to include non-violent events. Results in Appendix F show that the main finding—shutdowns are less likely in districts with higher ruling party support—remains consistent. However, when considering all events, opposition-led activities no longer significantly influence shutdowns. Physical repression also displays different patterns

⁷Districts are categorized as ruling party strongholds if the Chief Minister’s vote share exceeds that of the main opposition party by at least 10%; as swing districts if the margin is within 10%; and as opposition strongholds if the opposition’s vote share exceeds the ruling party’s by at least 10%.

of responsiveness to this broader set of events. In contrast to my main findings, physical repression does not appear significantly related to political support when controlling for all events occurring in a district-week. Moreover, physical repression is positively related to opposition-led events, although events that are unaffiliated with opposition parties still exert a stronger, positive effect on the use of physical repression. This divergence suggests that internet shutdowns are more selectively deployed in response to threatening political violence, while physical repression responds more broadly to various political activities.

6.3 ACLED bias

The reliance on ACLED data raises concerns about potential underreporting in less accessible or sparsely populated areas (Clarke, 2023). To mitigate this bias, I refine the analysis to focus on urban districts, identified as those with a population density above the national median using WorldPop 2020 data. Urban areas, with better media coverage and reporting infrastructure, provide more reliable data. Results, detailed in Appendix G, mirror those of the main analysis, confirming that the observed relationships between political support, violence, and internet shutdowns are not artifacts of reporting bias but reflect genuine patterns.

6.4 Regional and temporal heterogeneity

To better understand the factors influencing internet shutdowns in India, I conducted stratified analyses to examine regional and temporal variations in their implementation.

The first analysis investigates how partisan alignment shapes the use of internet shutdowns, focusing on the influence of the BJP, the national ruling party. I re-estimate models separately for BJP-governed states and those led by opposition parties. As detailed in Appendix H.1, BJP-ruled states exhibit a strong negative correlation between political support for the ruling party and the likelihood of internet shutdowns. This pattern is absent in opposition-ruled states, suggesting that the ability to deploy shutdowns strategically is influenced by alignment with the national government.

In BJP-governed states, alignment with the central government provides institutional

control and federal backing, enabling more precise deployment of shutdowns, particularly in opposition-dominated areas or during critical periods like elections and protests. This capacity stems from the dual control of IAS officers, who are employed by state governments but regulated by the central government, allowing BJP-led states to implement shutdowns effectively. In contrast, opposition-ruled states face limited institutional leverage and potential resistance from the central government, constraining their ability to deploy shutdowns strategically.

These findings underscore that internet shutdowns, while locally executed, ultimately serve national strategic interests. In BJP-ruled states, shutdowns not only suppress dissent but also align with the federal government’s broader objective of limiting opposition mobilization. In opposition-led states, similar incentives to use shutdowns exist but are less actionable due to institutional constraints and national support.

Finally, I examine how electoral cycles impact internet shutdown patterns. Focusing on years with state legislative assembly elections and the 2019 general election, results presented in Appendix H.2 show that the patterns observed in the main analysis are not primarily driven by years in which state elections took place. However, during the 2019 general election, the relationship between ruling party support and reduced shutdown likelihood became more pronounced, suggesting that heightened political stakes during national elections influence shutdown deployment. These results indicate that national elections introduce unique dynamics, likely reflecting intensified strategic calculations tied to maintaining political control.

7 Conclusion

This study offers an in-depth analysis of internet shutdowns in India, revealing how these measures are strategically deployed. The variations in the use of internet shutdowns within India reveal that state officials leverage this tool against opposition strongholds, in response to opposition-led violence, and as a cover for state-led military actions. This contrasts starkly with the patterns observed in physical repression, which do not seem to align with such calculated political motives or targeted precision. Digital tactics, like internet shutdowns,

offer governments a swift, cost-effective, and highly localized means to suppress dissent or perceived threats. This is a marked deviation from physical repression, hampered by logistical limitations, such as the need for force mobilization, which make it less adaptable to rapidly changing political circumstances.

These observations have important implications for the democratic potential of digital technology. Initially, the internet was heralded as a tool for liberation. However, its exploitation by governments for repressive purposes has significantly tainted this promise. Digital tools offer an efficient, cost-effective means of repression, potentially increasing their appeal to governments, including those that might have previously avoided overt repressive measures. The precision and lower visibility of digital repression tactics also allow for a more targeted and impactful suppression. The advent of advanced digital technologies, therefore, introduces a potent form of state repression with worrying consequences for political freedoms globally.

Looking ahead, future research in this field can further illuminate the dynamics of digital repression. A more nuanced analysis of network disruptions, differentiating among filtering, throttling, censoring, and complete shutdowns, would provide deeper insights into the operationalization and strategic choices within digital repression. Exploring the impact of both digital and physical repression on local political dynamics and public support could shed light on the broader implications for governments that employ these tactics. Furthermore, while this study focuses on India, internet shutdowns are increasingly observed worldwide. Future research should explore these tactics in different geopolitical contexts to understand how repressive strategies vary across regions and under various regime types. Such comparative studies would enrich our understanding of internet shutdowns as part of the larger landscape of state repression.

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Appendix

A Distribution of political support

Table A.A.I. Summary statistics for political support by state

	Mean support	Min support	Max support
Total	5.25	-61.64	86.33
Andhra Pradesh	4.97	-11.89	26.26
Arunachal Pradesh	-2.14	-61.64	49.67
Assam	-3.71	-52.47	35.08
Bihar	-7.06	-29.88	20.49
Chhatisgarh	6.48	-14.89	27.43
Goa	3.15	-3.51	9.284
Gujarat	4.22	-18.32	25.45
Haryana	4.80	-18.59	28.73
Himachal Pradesh	5.75	-13.44	27.07
Jammu & Kashmir	-11.90	-51.65	35.30
Jharkhand	-0.40	-43.57	22.06
Karnataka	-5.38	-56.36	24.76
Kerala	-0.856	-23.19	20.57
Ladakh	-31.44	-51.45	-16.52
Madhya Pradesh	1.13	-25.79	25.79
Maharashtra	-2.56	-38.82	31.15
Manipur	-2.41	-48.62	39.56
Meghalaya	-6.64	-49.62	32.88
Mizoram	4.88	-25.56	25.56
Nagaland	0.62	-26.11	35.01
NCT of Delhi	20.12	7.31	40.03
Orissa	11.22	-23.28	34.54
Pondicherry	-1.79	-51.94	64.52
Punjab	5.08	-18.27	22.96
Rajasthan	1.87	-25.83	25.83
Sikkim	9.13	-3.83	27.77
Tamil Nadu	59.46	2.267	86.33
Telangana	12.51	-17.91	26.34
Tripura	-4.00	-55.65	28.24
Uttar Pradesh	7.85	-42.62	35.15
Uttarakhand	7.53	-8.72	16.97
West Bengal	17.04	-32.32	37.31

B Identifying and classifying ACLED events

This coding procedures used to classify the perpetrators of ACLED events was adapted from a working paper by Lauren Young and Marika Miner titled "A Global Analysis of the Targeting and Effects of Election Violence."

B.1 Identifying disorder events

I subset all ACLED events to only include those associated with collective action and violent disorder by excluding events with the following sub-event types: Agreement, Change to group activity, Headquarters or base established, Non-violent transfer of territory, Peaceful protest, and Other. Figure A.B.1 shows the number of violent events in India by state.

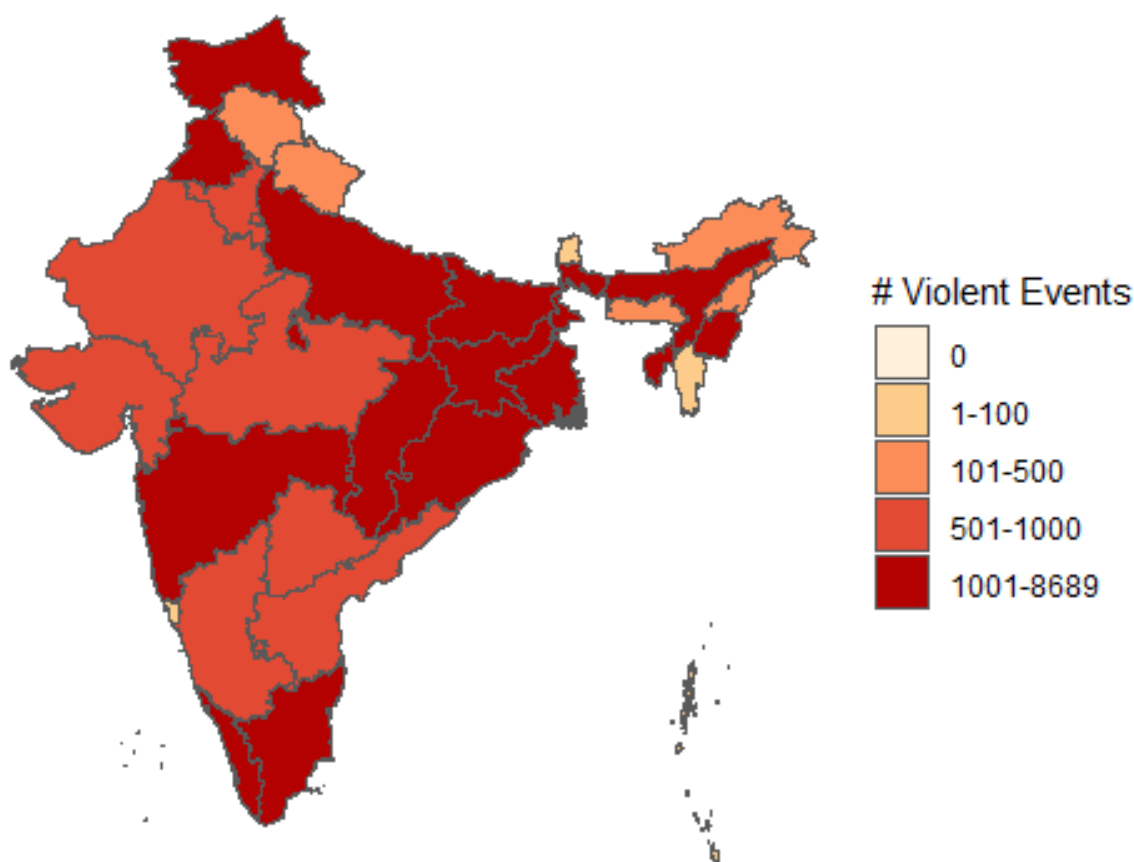


Figure A.B.1. Violent events by state, 2016-2022

B.2 Defining event perpetrators

To identify the perpetrators of violent events in the ACLED data I used the event actor and associated actor variables in ACLED, using a sub-event type-specific logic. The identification rules are as follows:

1. Actor 1 and associated actor 1 are the perpetrators
 - (a) Abduction/forced disappearance
 - (b) Air/drone strike
 - (c) Arrests
 - (d) Attack
 - (e) Grenade
 - (f) Looting/property destruction
 - (g) Remote explosive/landmine/IED
 - (h) Sexual Violence
 - (i) Shelling/artillery/missile attack
 - (j) Suicide bomb
2. Actor 1 and associated actor 1 and actor 2 and associated actor 2 are both the perpetrators
 - (a) Armed clash
 - (b) Excessive force against protesters
 - (c) Disrupted weapons use
 - (d) Government regains territory
 - (e) Protest with intervention
3. Actor 1 and associated actor 1 and actor 2 and associated actor 2 are both the perpetrators unless actor 2 is coded as civilians ($\text{inter2} = 7$). When actor 2 is coded as civilians, then actor 1 and associated actor 1 are the perpetrators

- (a) Mob violence
- (b) Violent demonstration

B.3 Identifying opposition perpetrated violence

I identify disorder events that are perpetrated by opposition parties by finding matches between the event perpetrators and the opposition political parties and their affiliates for each state. The set of opposition parties for each state-year consist of all district-level opposition parties in that state identified as those which received the highest district-level vote share in the most recent prior assembly election, when excluding the party of the Chief Minister, during the year the event took place. In order to identify opposition-affiliated groups, I created a list of all district-level opposition parties in India during the study period. I then researched each party to find their affiliated groups, which often include the party's youth wing, women's group, and armed faction. Table A.B.I and Figure A.B.2 show the distribution opposition-perpetrated violent events in each state during the study period.

Table A.B.I. Summary statistics for violent events by state

	Violent events	Opposition violence	% Opposition violence
Total	36,380	2,996	8.24
Andaman & Nicobar Islands	14	0	0.00
Andhra Pradesh	720	156	21.67
Arunachal Pradesh	238	7	2.94
Assam	1,411	157	11.13
Bihar	1,437	88	6.12
Chandigarh	244	0	0.00
Chhatisgarh	1,251	11	0.88
Dadra & Nagar Haveli	1	0	0.00
Daman & Diu	2	0	0.00
Goa	67	6	8.96
Gujarat	935	49	5.24
Haryana	942	25	2.65
Himachal Pradesh	159	30	18.87
Jammu & Kashmir	8,689	49	0.56
Jharkhand	1,107	42	3.79
Karnataka	621	91	14.65
Kerala	1,119	163	14.57
Ladakh	21	1	4.76
Lakshadweep	0	0	0.00
Madhya Pradesh	672	44	6.55
Maharashtra	1,047	93	8.88
Manipur	1,164	29	2.49
Meghalaya	295	1	0.34
Mizoram	40	1	2.50
NCT of Delhi	696	64	9.20
Nagaland	132	0	0.00
Orissa	1,516	149	9.83
Pondicherry	112	1	0.89
Punjab	1,934	269	13.91
Rajasthan	623	37	5.94
Sikkim	29	12	41.38
Tamil Nadu	1,631	120	7.36
Telangana	606	55	9.08
Tripura	1,082	85	7.86
Uttar Pradesh	2,461	184	7.48
Uttarakhand	256	18	7.03
West Bengal	3,106	959	30.88

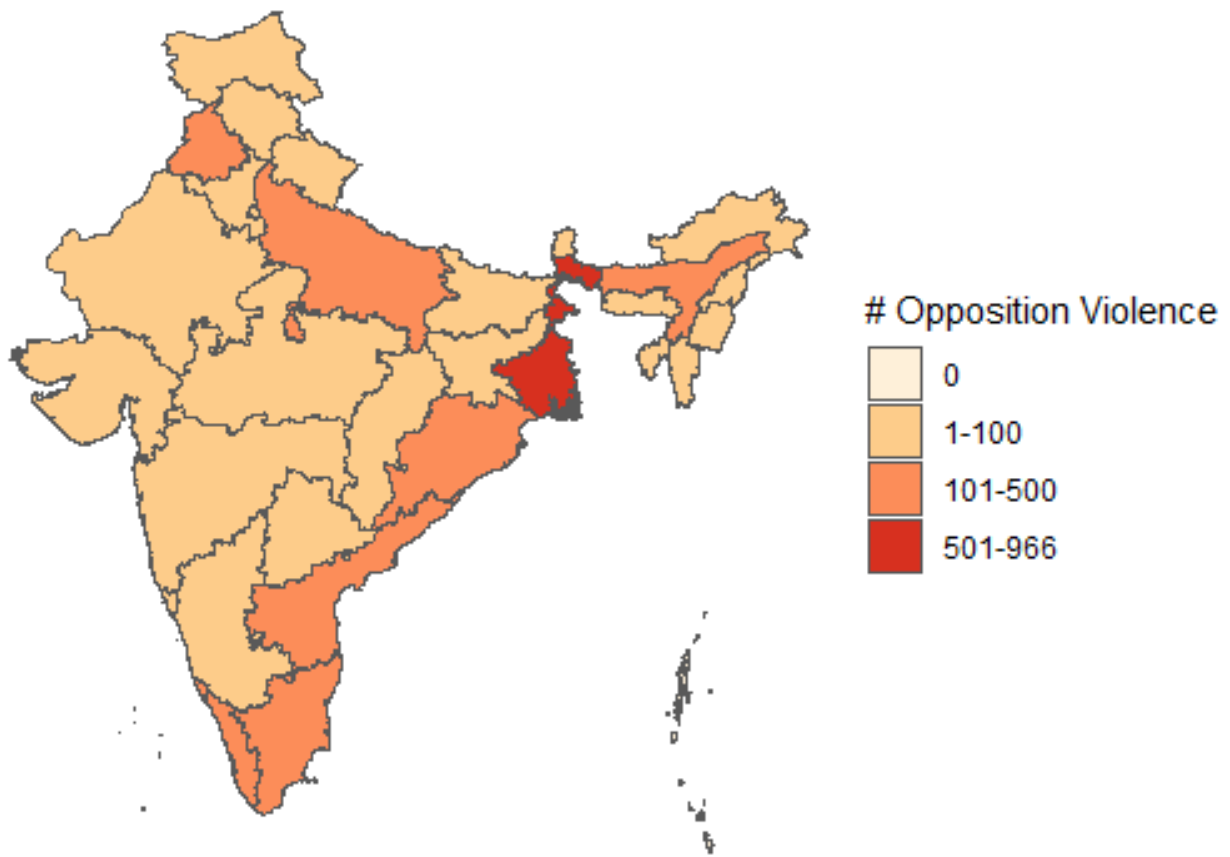


Figure A.B.2. Opposition-perpetrated violent events by state, 2016-2022

B.4 Identifying military-led violence

To identify violent events that are perpetrated by the military, I first removed events considered to be protests, riots, arrests, or disrupted weapons use. The remaining events are classified as being military-led if the event perpetrator is coded as Governments and State Security Services ($inter = 1$). Figure A.B.3 shows the number of military-led violent events in each state.

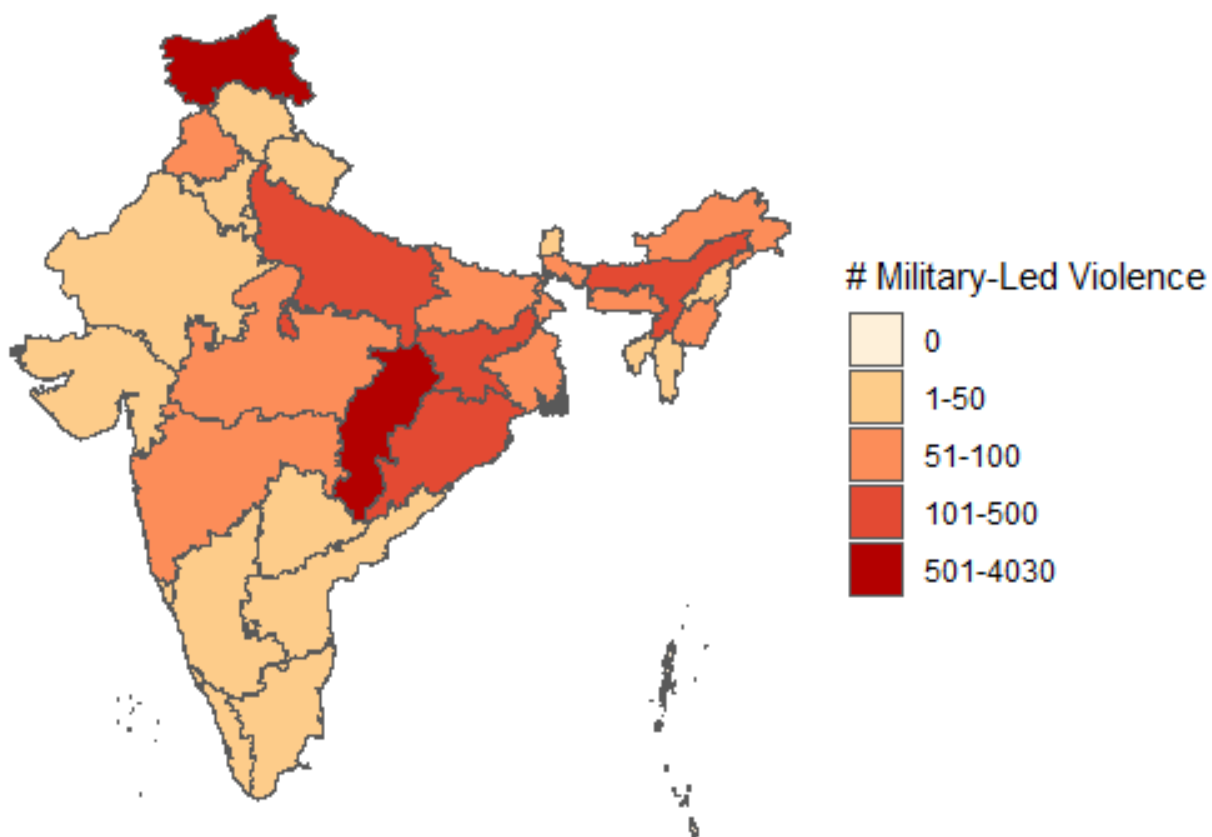


Figure A.B.3. Military-led violent events by state, 2016-2022

B.5 Identifying physical state repression

To identify physical state repression, I first removed events considered to be peaceful protests, explosion/remote violence, battles, or disrupted weapons. I then subset these events to those with the following interaction codes: 15 (Military vs Rioters), 16 (Military vs Protesters), 17 (Military vs Civilians). The remaining events are classified as physical state repression if the event perpetrator is coded as Governments and State Security Services ($\text{inter} = 1$). Figure A.B.4 shows the number of physical repression events in each state.

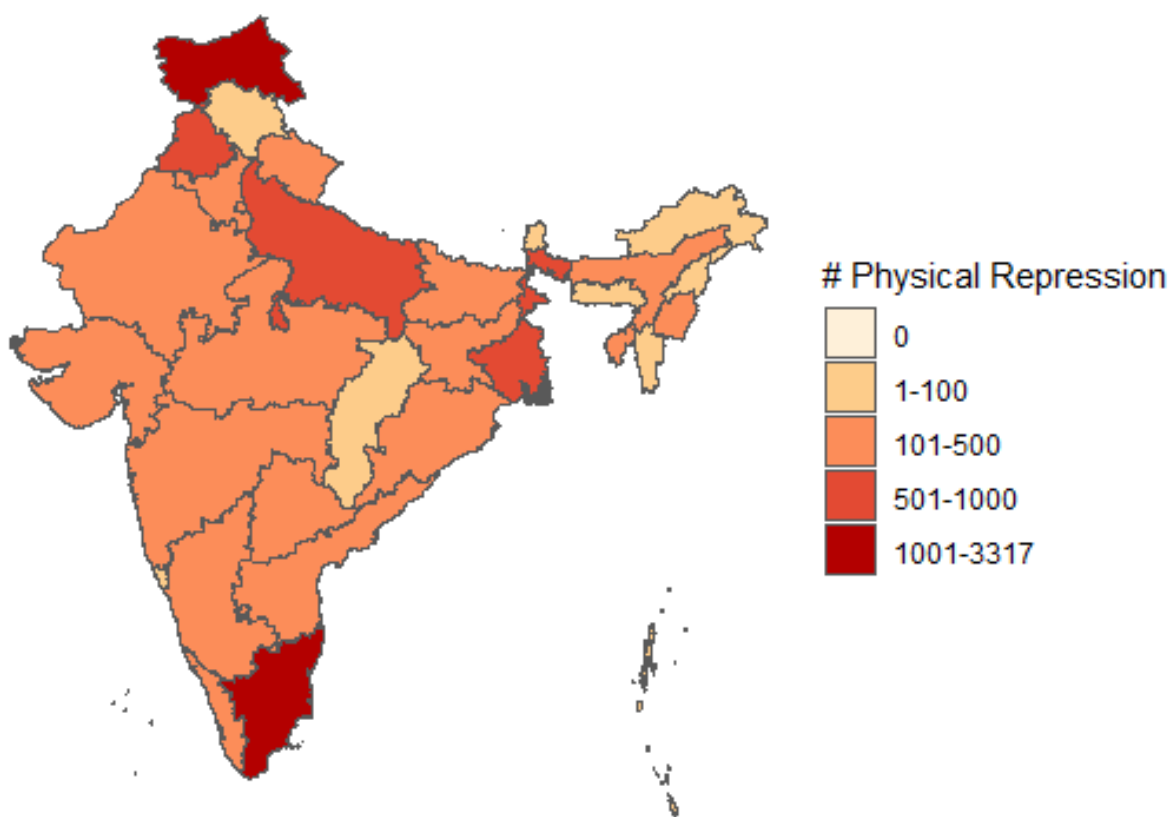


Figure A.B.4. Physical state repression events by state, 2016-2022

C Justifications for internet shutdowns in India

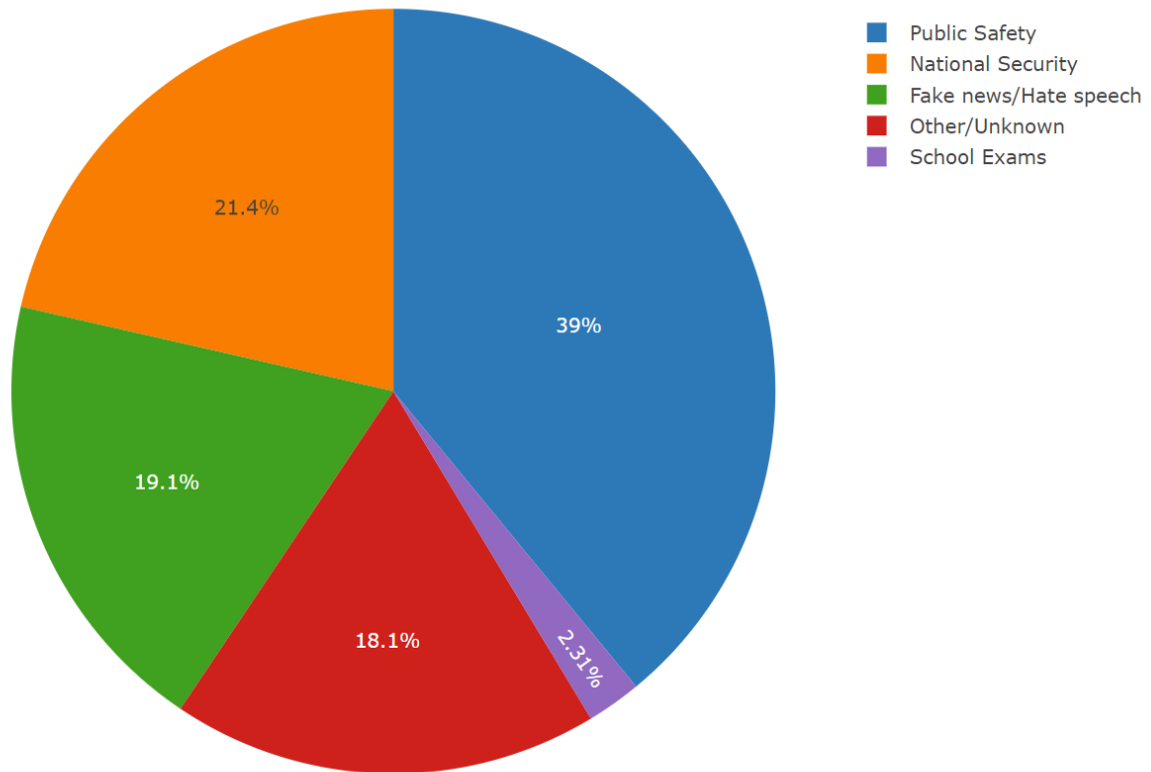


Figure A.C.1. Internet shutdowns in India by official justification

D Joint models with opposition violence and ruling party violence

Table A.D.I. Political support for the state ruling party and opposition violence

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election $t-1$}	-0.0247*** (0.0046)	-0.0232*** (0.0041)	-0.0233*** (0.0042)	0.0080*** (0.0028)	0.0087*** (0.0030)	0.0087*** (0.0030)
Opposition violence _{$t-1$}		0.1825 (0.1263)	0.1319 (0.2287)		0.1042 (0.0835)	0.1164 (0.1047)
Unaffiliated violence _{$t-1$}		0.1097*** (0.0100)	0.1102*** (0.0093)		0.3963*** (0.1085)	0.3965*** (0.1088)
Violent exposure _{$t-1$}		0.0596*** (0.0105)	0.0598*** (0.0106)		0.0489** (0.0246)	0.0488** (0.0248)
Political support _{Election $t-1$} *Opposition violence _{$t-1$}			0.0037 (0.0085)			-0.0009 (0.0042)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	163,200	163,200	163,200	248,292	248,292	248,292
Pseudo R ²	0.39802	0.41101	0.41106	0.09772	0.12167	0.12167

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A.D.II. Opposition and ruling party violence

	Internet shutdown		Physical repression	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Opposition violence _{<i>t</i>-1}	0.2739*** (0.0623)	0.2919* (0.1566)	0.1436*** (0.0347)	0.0321 (0.0645)
Ruling party violence _{<i>t</i>-1}		-0.0340 (0.1358)		-0.0427 (0.0398)
Unaffiliated violence _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0296 (0.0249)		0.1915*** (0.0186)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0131 (0.0126)		0.0693*** (0.0102)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
District	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	45,390	45,390	229,779	229,779
Pseudo R ²	0.39454	0.39509	0.22103	0.22943

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

E Alternate political support measures

Table A.E.I. Political support for the state ruling party - vote majority

	Internet shutdown		Physical repression	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
CM win _{Election t-1}	-0.6941** (0.2819)	-0.6257*** (0.2428)	0.3001*** (0.1072)	0.3066** (0.1201)
Violent events _{t-1}		0.1102*** (0.0142)		0.3634*** (0.0881)
Violent exposure _{t-1}		0.0659*** (0.0109)		0.0467* (0.0249)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
State	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	163,200	163,200	248,292	248,292
Pseudo R ²	0.38861	0.40349	0.09788	0.12096

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A.E.II. Political support for the state ruling party - category

	Internet shutdown		Physical repression	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Opposition stronghold _{Election t-1}	1.059*** (0.3282)	0.9516*** (0.2813)	-0.2156 (0.1598)	-0.2422 (0.1860)
Swing district _{Election t-1}	0.1210 (0.1539)	0.0206 (0.1267)	-0.1284 (0.1213)	-0.1370 (0.1283)
Violent events _{t-1}		0.1047*** (0.0154)		0.3651*** (0.0874)
Violent exposure _{t-1}		0.0654*** (0.0105)		0.0462* (0.0250)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
State	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	163,200	163,200	248,292	248,292
Pseudo R ²	0.39531	0.40926	0.09665	0.11983

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A.E.III. Opposition perpetrated violence by political support category on internet shutdowns

	Opposition		Ruling Party		Swing	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Opposition violence _{<i>t</i>-1}	-0.3139 (1.026)	-0.1801 (0.9957)	0.2780* (0.1512)	0.0826 (0.1654)	0.6828*** (0.2051)	0.6836*** (0.2310)
Unaffiliated violence _{<i>t</i>-1}		-0.0174** (0.0089)		0.1564 (0.1050)		0.1287* (0.0698)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		-0.0198* (0.0106)		0.0606* (0.0362)		0.0413 (0.0340)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
District	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	6,656	6,656	4,160	4,160	6,460	6,460
Pseudo R ²	0.46258	0.46328	0.25303	0.26088	0.27320	0.27707

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A.E.IV. Opposition perpetrated violence by political support category on physical repression

	Opposition		Ruling Party		Swing	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Opposition violence _{<i>t</i>-1}	0.0134 (0.1181)	-0.2069 (0.1654)	0.1604*** (0.0407)	0.0582 (0.0424)	0.1135** (0.0529)	-0.0038 (0.0794)
Unaffiliated violence _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.1308*** (0.0268)		0.1469*** (0.0234)		0.2076*** (0.0184)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0702*** (0.0082)		0.0423*** (0.0093)		0.0545*** (0.0091)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
District	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	32,131	32,131	78,170	78,170	97,756	97,756
Pseudo R ²	0.27350	0.28332	0.22168	0.22477	0.22120	0.22629

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

F Looking beyond violent events

Table A.F.I. Political support for the state ruling party with total events

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election t-1}	-0.0247*** (0.0046)	-0.0266*** (0.0042)	-0.0243*** (0.0046)	0.0080*** (0.0028)	0.0042 (0.0031)	0.0057* (0.0030)
Total events _{t-1}		0.0632*** (0.0150)	0.0580*** (0.0171)		0.2708*** (0.0440)	0.2772*** (0.0463)
Total exposure _{t-1}		0.0264*** (0.0071)	0.0262*** (0.0070)		0.0133 (0.0115)	0.0132 (0.0115)
Political support _{Election t-1} *Total Events _{t-1}			-0.0006*** (0.0002)			-0.0008*** (0.0002)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	163,200	163,200	163,200	248,292	248,292	248,292
Pseudo R ²	0.39802	0.40463	0.40496	0.09772	0.14326	0.14349

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1

Table A.F.II. Opposition perpetrated total events

	Internet shutdown		Physical repression	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Opposition events _{t-1}	0.1927** (0.0920)	0.1544 (0.0970)	0.1713*** (0.0201)	0.0981*** (0.0160)
Unaffiliated events _{t-1}		0.0536** (0.0273)		0.1056*** (0.0065)
Total exposure _{t-1}		0.0272* (0.0151)		0.0395*** (0.0067)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
District	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	45,390	45,390	229,779	229,779
Pseudo R ²	0.39458	0.39795	0.22224	0.23100

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1

G ACLED bias

Table A.G.1. Political support for the state ruling party in urban areas

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election t-1}	-0.0212*** (0.0033)	-0.0207*** (0.0033)	-0.0238*** (0.0033)	0.0100*** (0.0034)	0.0094** (0.0038)	0.0088** (0.0036)
Violent events _{t-1}		0.1137*** (0.0243)	0.1542*** (0.0191)		0.4067*** (0.0739)	0.4024*** (0.0711)
Violent exposure _{t-1}		0.0251*** (0.0096)	0.0242*** (0.0092)		0.0270 (0.0226)	0.0274 (0.0231)
Political support _{Election t-1} *Violent events _{t-1}			0.0021*** (0.0006)			0.0007 (0.0014)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	74,412	74,412	74,412	124,146	124,146	124,146
Pseudo R ²	0.48329	0.48858	0.48935	0.09222	0.11677	0.11682

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1

Table A.G.2. Opposition perpetrated violence in urban areas

	Internet shutdown		Physical repression	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Opposition violence _{t-1}	0.2594*** (0.0648)	0.2494*** (0.0634)	0.1500*** (0.0321)	0.0140 (0.0438)
Unaffiliated violence _{t-1}		0.0401 (0.0252)		0.1949*** (0.0137)
Violent exposure _{t-1}		0.0131 (0.0159)		0.0674*** (0.0138)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
District	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	25,272	25,272	123,057	123,057
Pseudo R ²	0.45415	0.45493	0.20988	0.21974

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1

Table A.G.3. Military-led violence in urban areas

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Shutdown _{<i>t</i>-1}	0.1441*** (0.0451)	0.1105*** (0.0238)		
Physical repression _{<i>t</i>-1}			0.0295 (0.0217)	-0.0218 (0.0168)
Violent events _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0231 (0.0143)		0.0280 (0.0173)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0058** (0.0027)		0.0059** (0.0028)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
District	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	125,961	125,961	125,961	125,961
R ²	0.22393	0.23215	0.22285	0.23138

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

H Regional and temporal heterogeneity

H.1 State political party control

Table A.H.1. Political support for the state ruling party in BJP-controlled states

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election $t-1$}	-0.0574*** (0.0151)	-0.0552*** (0.0156)	-0.0535*** (0.0135)	0.0065 (0.0091)	0.0125* (0.0067)	0.0111* (0.0063)
Violent events _{$t-1$}		0.0627*** (0.0116)	-0.0232 (0.1568)		0.2909*** (0.0946)	0.3144*** (0.1044)
Violent exposure _{$t-1$}		0.0155* (0.0089)	0.0146 (0.0100)		0.0740*** (0.0086)	0.0758*** (0.0070)
Political support _{Election $t-1$} *Violent events _{$t-1$}			-0.0028 (0.0047)			0.0018 (0.0017)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	55,068	55,068	55,068	111,154	111,154	111,154
Pseudo R ²	0.49135	0.49328	0.49351	0.10880	0.13080	0.13107

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A.H.2. Political support for the state ruling party in non-BJP controlled states

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election $t-1$}	0.0375 (0.0266)	0.0270 (0.0224)	0.0260 (0.0219)	0.0105 (0.0088)	0.0057 (0.0063)	0.0061 (0.0058)
Violent events _{$t-1$}		0.2387*** (0.0455)	0.2236*** (0.0567)		0.4490*** (0.0942)	0.4685*** (0.1053)
Violent exposure _{$t-1$}		0.0544* (0.0285)	0.0549* (0.0290)		0.0231 (0.0283)	0.0229 (0.0287)
Political support _{Election $t-1$} *Violent events _{$t-1$}			0.0021 (0.0029)			-0.0014 (0.0023)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	34,447	34,447	34,447	135,931	135,931	135,931
Pseudo R ²	0.35165	0.36517	0.36533	0.10787	0.13231	0.13240

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

H.2 Election years

Table A.H.3. Political support for the state ruling party in state assembly election years

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election $t-1$}	0.0147 (0.0170)	0.0150 (0.0161)	0.0124 (0.0182)	0.0122** (0.0056)	0.0110** (0.0055)	0.0108** (0.0055)
Violent events _{$t-1$}		0.3320 (0.3079)	0.4869 (0.3650)		0.4405*** (0.1101)	0.4373*** (0.1047)
Violent exposure _{$t-1$}		0.1708 (0.1996)	0.1705 (0.2004)		-0.0170 (0.0242)	-0.0170 (0.0242)
Political support _{Election $t-1$} *Violent events _{$t-1$}			0.0072 (0.0075)			0.0004 (0.0024)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,258	2,258	2,258	45,077	45,077	45,077
Pseudo R ²	0.11188	0.12060	0.12172	0.09531	0.10833	0.10834

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A.H.4. Political support for the state ruling party in 2019

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election $t-1$}	-0.0493*** (0.0127)	-0.0466*** (0.0143)	-0.0508*** (0.0135)	-0.0031 (0.0097)	-0.0002 (0.0072)	-0.0009 (0.0078)
Violent events _{$t-1$}		0.0988*** (0.0372)	0.1787*** (0.0271)		0.2482*** (0.0732)	0.2476*** (0.0678)
Violent exposure _{$t-1$}		0.0057 (0.0137)	0.0068 (0.0134)		0.0233 (0.0232)	0.0237 (0.0231)
Political support _{Election $t-1$} *Violent events _{$t-1$}			0.0030*** (0.0007)			0.0007 (0.0011)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	15,059	15,059	15,059	35,152	35,152	35,152
Pseudo R ²	0.43627	0.44317	0.44595	0.11325	0.13074	0.13081

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

I Linear probability models

Table A.I.1. Political support for the state ruling party

	Internet shutdown			Physical repression		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Political support _{Election $t-1$}	-0.0002 (0.0001)	-0.0002 (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	0.0003** (0.0001)	0.0003** (0.0001)	0.0003** (0.0001)
Violent events _{$t-1$}		0.0048*** (0.0017)	0.0050*** (0.0008)		0.0430*** (0.0038)	0.0429*** (0.0038)
Violent exposure _{$t-1$}		0.0024* (0.0013)	0.0023* (0.0012)		0.0058 (0.0039)	0.0059 (0.0039)
Political support _{Election $t-1$} *Violent events _{$t-1$}			-0.0003*** (8.16×10^{-5})			0.0002 (0.0001)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>						
State	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	248,292	248,292	248,292	248,292	248,292	248,292
R ²	0.06606	0.07469	0.07966	0.04022	0.06634	0.06650

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A.I.2. Opposition perpetrated violence

	Internet shutdown		Physical repression	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Opposition violence _{<i>t</i>-1}	0.0027* (0.0014)	0.0008 (0.0018)	0.0166*** (0.0044)	-0.0011 (0.0067)
Unaffiliated violence _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0021*** (0.0004)		0.0252*** (0.0023)
Violent exposure _{<i>t</i>-1}		0.0009* (0.0005)		0.0070** (0.0030)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
District	✓	✓	✓	✓
Week	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	251,196	251,196	251,196	251,196
R ²	0.14154	0.14257	0.12770	0.13785

Clustered (state & week) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*